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Byron Stripling

Byron Stripling has made his mark in jazz and popular music with his virtuoso trumpet work and captivating stage presence. He has played lead trumpet with the Count Basie Orchestra, the Lionel Hampton Big Band and the Lincoln Center Jazz Orchestra, and has appeared as a guest soloist with numerous pops orchestras across the country. Byron has worked as a singer and actor on Broadway in "Satchmo" and "From Second Avenue to Broadway." His voice and trumpet can be heard on jingles and at major television events, and he is in constant demand as a clinician and motivational speaker.

Byron was interviewed in Clinton, New York on April 24, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're filming on the campus of Hamilton College today for the Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Byron Stripling with me today, who has put some great time in at a jazz festival here, trumpeter, vocalist, actor, motivator. As a young man were you one of those people who liked to get up on the stage? Was that something that seemed to be part of your character even at a young age?

BS: Not necessarily, but I think in all of our lives things happen and they sort of lead to something else, for me and I think for a lot of black people. Is it okay to say black on the tape?

MR: I think black is okay.

BS: Or do I have to say African American? I still say black, I haven't shifted yet, you know.

MR: I think we're back to black actually.

BS: Are we back to black?

MR: We're definitely not Afro-American. That's supposed to be —

BS: African-American. I mean I understand why the term is but I've got to just change my habit and it's a longer word to say, so I just still say black.

MR: I'll say black if you say black, all right?

BS: Okay that's cool. But a lot of black people I think have the church as their foundation and I was often, all the time in church, because my father was the choir director. And so I didn't really have a choice in terms of the singing thing. And also when nobody wanted to take a particular solo, then my father said you've got to sing the tenor solo, or the baritone. I was both because he lacked tenors and he lacked baritones. So that's where I think my first performing thing started to really come into effect. And when I would have to learn a solo, and many times it was a classical solo because my father did a lot of — like we did the Handel Messiah, and Schubert Mass in G, and all these like little church

performing thing. But I wasn't one of those kids that was pushed on stage at all. You know it's just a nurturing of a love. You know my family had so much music and music became like an integral part of our lives, and I learned very early on, as you spoke about how you had the radio under your pillow, you know many nights, and it's the same with me. When I was growing up they first had those little cassette tape recorders that you could buy at Radio Shack. They were real poor quality, but actually we've been with Ed Shaughnessy here for a couple of days, and what I used to do, and what makes me think about that is The Tonight Show, is I would record, like if I'd watch The Tonight Show and if they say okay tonight we're going to have Della Reese and we're going to have this guy or Sammy Davis, and he's going to do a duet with Doc Severinsen and that, so I'd take my tape recorder and record that particular thing and I had like, and that's what was the one great thing about that show was that they had like such a variety of artists, jazz people, they had a classical singer like Beverly Sills come on with just a piano player and sing, you know I'd record the stuff and I'd have like this composite tape of all these great artists. And that would go under my pillow at night as I listened to it, or I'd listen to the jazz radio station and do the same thing. They'd say the next thing is going to be some trumpet this or that. I'd press record. So you get a great composite tape that way.

MR: What denomination was the church?

BS: It was Baptist.

MR: When the music was used in the church, was it fairly strict to follow the music or was there a bit of improvising that went on in a Gospel sense?

BS: In the Gospel part yeah there was definitely some, but more than the varying of improvisation because a lot of — I've got to be honest — my impression is that a lot of music claims to have improvisation, I mean you'll get classical people that say, you might have heard people on T.V. say on panels with jazz musicians, "Oh yeah, I improvise too as a classical musician; I put my trills in different places and I do this." And Gospel improvises, rock musicians improvise, but jazz is a whole other level of improvisation. So in the jazz sense we weren't improvising but the thing I think with Gospel music was the feeling was certainly there. And for me, again you realize the power of the music, when I would see people like my grandmother, who never had a high school education even, who was a poor speller and a poor reader, but yet she put three of her children through college through just working her ass off. And when she would go to church and all they would do was play about four bars of one of her favorite hymns, and she would begin to shout. Now that is confusing to a young person, it's like walking in when you're young and seeing somebody making love. You don't really know what that is. And it's the same with seeing your mother or your grandmother get the spirit in the

giving everything up to the Lord. She's been working her behind off. She's very happy, her children are not in jail, that she was able to provide a better way for them, for her kids. And this is such joy for her and she thanks God for it. But it took me a long time. Because all I knew was, "Mom, Grandma's freaking me out, she's over there screaming and shouting and I don't know why." Think about that, it's a weird feeling for a kid, it's all those impressions you get when you're a kid that stick in your mind, those kind of impressions, and the fact that the music was that powerful and could do that to her was very interesting to me. And so when you have experiences like that with music, and I know in my own life and I'm sure in your life, you've had music sort of bring you out of depressions, music gives you a high, and it's really a powerful anchor that can give you the spirit of what you need to do. And I think that's why you and I and every other great musician are in this business. It's not for money it's for the feeling that it gives us.

MR: I can tell that you try to get that idea across to students too when you talk to them.

BS: Yeah. I think ultimately — I'm sorry — I can relax for a second, I talk too loud, don't I?

MR: Rubbing again?

BS: I'm going to zip this up, because I don't want any girls to get turned on.

MR: That's right.

BS: If they see my hair on my chest.

MR: We'll have to put an "X" on this one. Okay. Let me repeat that.
That feeling of the power of music, that a number of times I've seen you in front of a group of kids now, I can tell that that's pretty important to you to try to get across to them.

BS: Yeah, well you know I think ultimately, Monk, it's no good to have something and you can't share it. And from the beginning, whenever I've learned something that has affected my life I've immediately wanted to share it with someone. And since I come from a family of teachers, I also feel that I'm a teacher sort of. I think really ultimately we all are teachers, but when I find a piece of music that affects me, when I learn something new, I immediately want to share it with somebody. But you know what? That is a sort of a selfish thing because when I get to tell somebody else about it, it reinforces whatever I've just learned too. That's one of the great things about teaching. You learn it, you share it with somebody else, but as you're repeating it you're imbedding it in your consciousness even more. So it's a sort of a double whammy, a double something —

MR: That will do.

BS: —that you get from it.

MR: Now you had mentioned that your family moved around quite a bit, you're from Atlanta but that you've lived in a number of different places.

MR: On the lam.

BS: You've got to keep on the run. No what happened was my father was a musician, a classical singer. And he's from Georgia, and he took the big step of going to Kentucky to get his Masters, Colorado to get his Doctorate, then we moved to Minnesota for a teaching gig, St. Louis he had a teaching gig, and he's finally settled in Texas, where he's been about twelve years. But it's just that process of getting degrees in different places. But this was a big step for our family because no one had moved out of Georgia. Everybody just sort of stayed there and you did what you did in Georgia. And that was — in later years it's fun to learn that, you know Emerson said, "Do the thing you fear, and the death of fear is certain." And for him, that was a fearful step, for he and my mother. And you've had this in your life when you and your wife or you have taken steps in your life the different things that your parents haven't done. Quickly for me, what does a musician do? My father and mother knew that musicians, there were these people out there, they sometimes heard on record, but what do they do? And my father and mother have often called me up and said, "Well what did you do today?" And I said, "Well I was just at Hamilton College, and I did a thing." And they say, "Well what are you doing today?" I say, "Well I don't have anything today, Dad." He's like, "You need to get a job."

MR: No kidding?

BS: So but look, Monk, if you don't understand that concept of, well maybe I'm not working for three days, four days, five days. Maybe I don't work for a week and a half. If you've been used to nine to five, see, us musicians here, and so few of us talk about it — and I make it my job to talk to students about it that want to go into music — so many of us — I'm not on a specific pension plan, I have to take that responsibility myself. I'm not on any college payroll for a health plan. I have to take that responsibility myself. So my parents didn't understand that. And I always tell kids, how many of you have been told by your parents you shouldn't go into music, just do this for fun, you'll enjoy it, it's great, but you need to get a real job. And usually I get sixty percent of the people say that when I'm speaking to people that are aspiring musicians. And I say you know what? Your parents are absolutely right, until you can prove them wrong. And that means that you have to then get ammunition and you have to be able to say well this is what I will do as a musician. These are the opportunities. And so one of the first things I do is have them make a list of everything you could do in music. And what I can do is sometimes I'll give them an average week for myself. This Monday I'm going to play a jingle for Jolly Jelly or some kind of thing like that, where I'll go in, I won't see the music ahead of time. Most times in the 21st century, that's my catch word, you're the only person in the

usually the only trumpet player there, they've already pre-recorded the track, and they're going to be like Byron play, here's some music, play this on top of it. Sometimes I'll go improvise something on top of it. Sometimes they won't want anything close to improvisation. Sometimes it'll be classically oriented. Sometimes they'll want the flugelhorn. It has to be very well in tune, playing with a synthesizer is very different in playing because the synthesizer is right on the pitch, which means I've got to pull out because we tend to play a little sharp as brass players and try to get a little edge. We play a little bit, just a little bit — so you have to adjust differently. There's all those things. You wouldn't want me to play flat, would you?

MR: Absolutely not.

BS: A little sharp is better, or it would really be a downer. There's that, then the other things, I'll go through a week of what I do. And I'll say okay, now I want you to write down all the things you could do as a musician. Shows, club dates, weddings, this, that, boom, boom, boom. Make that list. Then draw a line, and write on the other side the specific skills you will need to do those specific things. What will you need to be a club date musician? Do you have to learn tunes? Do you have to learn "Feelings?" Do you need to be just more attentive as you listen to the radio so you can sing that new song "And I Will Always Love You" Whitney Houston you know? Do you need to know the song you were singing just a few minutes ago. You know what I always confuse that song with, "Get by with a little help from my friends" [scats]. Remember the commercial, "Come to a Girls' Club and see/ come to a Girls club and be — You guys don't remember that.

MR: Wow. I don't remember that one.

BS: It's a Girls' Club, well anyway.

MR: Well maybe you played on it.

BS: Maybe I did. I hope I'm getting paid for it. What do you need to be a Broadway musician? Okay? And then you write next to it what skills you need. A studio musician. What do you need to be a soloist in a jazz club? What do you need to be a classical soloist? Sometimes I'll get a call to play with a concert band, to play just a classical oriented program, light classics. Play "Flight of the Bumblebee" or "Virgin dela Macarena" or something, some Rafael Mendez stuff. What are the skills? What do you need to do? And then draw another line, okay, how am I going to go about achieving those things. What kind of practice schedule am I going to have to set up to make these things happen for myself? And ultimately I always tell people, find out the thing you ultimately want to do. But just have these — whereas as the people used to say get a teaching degree so you'll have something to fall back on. And if you're finding finally like I did at that, you didn't want to fall back on that. I don't want to fall back on

something, I want to fall into something, and what I want to fall into is the things I want to do. I want to have the trumpet mouthpiece up to my lips, because I love that.

MR: Do you think if people set themselves for that safety net, that that's where they're going to end up going?

BS: Well I didn't want to say that, but I absolutely do. So I think if ultimately if you don't want to teach on that kind of level — I want to teach, I definitely want to teach, I love it. But I don't want to teach in that setting. I had so many friends graduate from school and now they're conducting elementary school bands, which is great and I talk to elementary school kids all the time, but that's just not my place and I know for many of my friends it's not either, but they fell back onto something, because that's all they knew what to fall back on. I wanted to make sure I didn't have anything to fall — I had to fall into either playing this trumpet or not doing anything, I don't know what else I would have done but you know it's always like I tell people, if you can think of anything else besides music that you'd like to do, then do that. Because this is going to take every ounce of sweat that you can muster up. It's really a hard profession, but the rewards that you get from it are so immense that if you want to do it, just do it one thousand percent.

MR: Your father, and your mother, even though they were into music, still wonder about your choice. Did they have an attitude, pro or con, about jazz in itself?

BS: No, they didn't have a problem with jazz, because I was very lucky with them, I came from that era of black — there's that word again — of black families, that stressed a couple of things you and I talked about before. First it was education. They come from that sort of Martin Luther King era where education is your way out, which they imparted that to me and it sticks with me and I still think, and as I study and try to help other people and help myself I realize that by increasing the quality of the product or service that I can deliver to people, I can always hopefully be employed, because the thing I always stress to young people is that you want to be the absolute best at what you do. You can ask any price that way, etcetera, etcetera. So there was the education thing they stressed, which they got from that era, that Martin Luther King era of get out of the ghetto, educate yourself, it goes to the next level. That was the first thing for them. And then the jazz thing, they were from that era of people that were proud of black entertainers. That era of people, it's so great, they had such pride and like, who was that? Sugar Ray —

MR: The fighter?

BS: The fighter. And even Keter Betts and Houston [Person] were talking about, "Man when he would fight, everyone, it was like that was a rallying point. It was like well they could kick us down but we've got the best athletes and we've got the best artists. And so we

into the hall, my mother and father's head just went a little bit higher. Because they were saying she's ours. This is something that we're proud of. And you can oppress us in all these other kinds of ways. But we've got these great artists, like Lena Horne they were so proud of, and they took me to see her. They took me to see Sarah Vaughan, Ella Fitzgerald twice, took me to see Duke Ellington three times, Count Basie I went a couple of times, then my father, there was this hall that would always have him, he would just drop me off and eight o'clock and pick me up at about one thirty, five dollars it cost to go in, if you didn't have a seat, it was a dance. They were so proud of all the great like black artists at that time, and entertainers, like Sammy Davis, who I didn't get to see, but if these people were on T.V., I don't know if you remember that group Hines, Hines and Dad, well Maurice Hines, the other Hines brother, he introduced me to my future wife. He became good friends. But whenever guys like that were on T.V., it was like my mom would say, "The Hines boys are on," or "Lena Horne's going to be on," and we'd all run to the T.V. to see this. So my parents didn't have a stigma about jazz. Their thing was like they were so proud of these people. And they knew that the problem they had was they knew that there were those people who were able to make a good living for themselves, but they didn't know what these other people did. And that's why for me they said look, go get an education, get an education degree so you can teach, have something to fall back on, and that's what musicians do. And so I had that illusion too. So what I had to do and again what I have told students is you've got to educate yourself, to find out what musicians do do — oh do, do — that was deep. But find out what musicians do and study them, ask them questions, say what do you do in an average day and how can I get to have — again, with that list, the skills to do those things, how can I prepare myself? And the one thing I know I'm on a tangent, but the one thing I think is that colleges should be doing the same thing because many times I think that unfortunately this whole big band thing that many colleges are into, it's great and it helps teach ensemble playing, but I want to make sure that when people leave college they've got skills to be employable musicians. And a lot of the big band training that they're getting, I don't know if that's necessarily, that should only be a part. Really they could almost start stressing improvisation these days because in the 21st century — my catch word again — I think there's going to be more opportunities for people to have little niches for themselves. You think of a guy like Anthony Braxton, this guy from ECM Records, he was recording with them for a while, he's got a market of people that really love his kind of music. And he's built a little audience for himself. That's what people are going to be doing. Through the Internet, building themselves a website, recording their own record, being able to download a selection from their new record, having somebody

my new guys I like, he's got a little website, I can order his records, I don't even have to go through a distributor. Go to the website, I can order through the website, he'll send me a good copy of it, I can read all about it and where his next gig is on the web. See it's interesting, we're going to be able to bypass a lot of things as time goes on. So I think it would be important for a college to teach that to young people as well as the other skills. Integrate new things into it.

MR: Plus you said, talking about not having a nine to five, that you don't have the health insurance and all that, and I don't know at what point young musicians start to realize that they have an added burden that they have to do that kind of thing themselves. That some company isn't taking care of their retirement and their health insurance and all that kind of thing.

BS: But I mean I don't know if you were in my lecture at IAJE.

MR: I was.

BS: Well here's the interesting thing about all that with musicians. We've been doing that for years, sort of taking responsibility for our own things. Well I'm sorry to say that it's happening more to everyone, and as companies come up with more catch phrases like "downsizing" and "outsizing," you know, companies are coming in these days — I was supposed to go to Japan in June with the Eastman Wind Ensemble, sponsored by Kodak. But Kodak couldn't do that because they had to lay off twelve hundred employees. Okay, and people find out and say well wait a minute, we have a slow period in February, in January, we have a slow period in August. Why don't we just like hire people almost adjunct or whatever. We need secretaries we'll hire them? We've got a big project coming in, we don't need full time secretaries. That's the way it's going. People are trying to figure out ways to save money. But here's the interesting thing about all of that. It's not putting people out of work, and I feel that unions want you to believe that, and I am a union person and actually I do have a pension program through the union, which is very good. What it does is it frees up the creative potential of people for different things. That's the only thing technology can do. So in other words where some job or somebody normally, let's think about the post office. And it will happen soon. In the post office they usually have a bunch of people behind there helping you with things, in New York they're very slow. What about pretty soon, the technology is already there it's just that they have to wait a few years until the union contracts run out. You go to the post office, you put your envelope on top of a machine, you press the buttons, you put in your dollar in a little thing. It comes out the amount of postage you need, you stick it on there, you throw it in the thing. You don't need a person to do that. Those people can be freed up for things that are more creative for them. The people will be happier and they won't have to

productive. Stop laughing Luis. People will be more productive. I got him on that. You can laugh.

MR: You're a fan and supporter of technology.

BS: My philosophy about technology isn't good it isn't bad, it just is. And we all definitely benefit from any innovations that happen in technology, so go with it. What are you going to do, fight it? It's not like I'm for or against it, it's just —

MR: It's there.

BS: It's there. And yeah, I'm for it when it can help improve my life. I have a microwave you know. I don't know what it's doing to me, somebody should study that really because I'm not sure we got the real deal on these microwaves causing any kind of cancer or something. I should probably get rid of mine.

MR: Well let me take you back for a minute. The vocalizing in the church was your first kind of serious exposure to music. When did the trumpet come along?

BS: Well the trumpet was there the whole time and I always listened to the trumpet, but in terms of you know you have more opportunities to sing in church than you do to play but actually what would happen is we had a great minister, Reverend Brown, and he loved classical music. And he started asking me to also play classical trumpet solos in church, which there's nothing better. Every trumpet player on Easter can get a gig too, you know? Even guys that suck, it's true. It's funny, I played this Easter I played a Corelli concerto, and the people went crazy. And I said well who have you been having here on Easter? They said, "Some guy who said he was a trumpet player, he was like a trumpet owner and he played once a year."

MR: A trumpet owner — I like that.

BS: People that play once a year on Easter. See 'cause on Easter you can get your price because all the trumpet players are busy, they're looking. So I always wait until the last minute you know. So anyway, these people, like they had some guy that was terrible and they never had a good trumpet player. So I started playing trumpet solos in church and things like that. And then I found out — it's another good thing for young people to check out too — I found out I could also through that same literature, play somebody's wedding. I mean "Trumpet Voluntary" sounds great for a bride as she's walking down the aisle or just as some music to get people in the mood, or any kind of little Baroque trumpet thing with organ sounds really pretty for a bride. But the one thing I learned that I could ask a bride was, "Who's playing your party afterwards?" And then all I had to do was to start to play some of the tunes that I heard on the radio like "Feelings" and "Just the Way You Are," those tunes that were popular in the '70s when I was in high school. You know you learn those tunes by ear on the radio, you find a group, get some sheet

what you do when you're first starting. But I found out, look, if somebody calls you and asks you to play the service, tell them that you've got a band too, and ask them what their favorite tune is, and they'll probably say, [sings] "Wise men say, only fools —" Are you laughing again, Luis? "Fools rush in."

MR: So did you start singing at these weddings too? The receptions?

BS: I'd sing a little bit, just a little bit. But you find somebody's favorite tune and you play it a couple of times for them, they think you're a good band. So between those two things you can start to get a performing thing going. And that's the most important thing as you're coming up when you're young, it's finding a place to perform. It's a hard niche to get into, but that's very important to do. And that's why church is so valuable. Not only for the religious experience that you get, but that it can provide people that even sometimes are just starting to learn their instruments. You get very little criticism in church you know, they'll let you sort of screw up a little bit.

MR: Right, very forgiving.

BS: They're very forgiving in church, it's true. And it's helped a lot of people. Look at Aretha Franklin was raised in the church through the way she sang, you know — was able to really get her talent going there. And so many artists have been like that.

MR: You mentioned an anecdote about getting to see Count Basie and so forth. Did you have aspirations to play in the big bands that were still around as a young man?

BS: Yeah absolutely. And I started a relationship with some of the guys in the band too because they'd come about three or four times a year to Minnesota, where I was living at the time. And I'd say look what's your address? And they gave me the address of Willard Alexander, the booking in New York that booked every big band I later found out — you know 660 Madison Avenue, New York, NY 1002 — whatever it was. It was the address, and you could just write, "The guy in the band, Count Basie Orchestra, Willard Alexander, 660 Madison Avenue," and I never forgot that address, because I would write this bass trombone player, Bill Hughes, the manager, or trumpet player at the time, Sonny Cohn, and I'd see these guys and I'd ask them questions and this and that, and so they sort of knew me from that. And I went with a bunch of bands before the Basie band, but then when they finally heard about me, they were like, "That's that kid that used to write us letters." And one thing that's important to that band is that you know the music. You know if you go in the drum chair in the Count Basie band, most of the charts are missing to the standards like "Shiny Stockings," and "One O'Clock Jump," and "Whirley-Bird," and all the hits. There's no music to those. And really there shouldn't be and doesn't have to be because if you're going in that band you have to know the music enough to play it by memory as the drummer. And even me when I went I had the shout chorus to "Shiny

O'Clock Jump" I had because I played that with records. You know you stand in a room and you pretend like you're lead trumpet player and you play with the records, like we've all done. And that's something that everybody has to do at some period in their lives. So yeah I definitely had aspirations to do it, and I'd already done it anyway in drill at home in my basement.

MR: Did you step into the lead chair?

BS: In the Basie band?

MR: Yeah.

BS: Um hum. Right to a lead chair. I had come right from Woody Herman's band.

MR: And Thad Jones was conducting at that time?

BS: Yeah actually I got there at a pivotal period. I got there right when Basie had died. And then Eric Dixon was the conductor. I don't know if you know Eric but he was a great tenor player in the band. He was Straw Boss during the later years. And it's a great sort of lesson about, I don't know if it's too trivial to tell on the tape, but a lesson about sort of business. It's always nice to observe stuff. Basie died and the guys said we want to keep the band going, let's try to keep it going. Eric Dixon is Straw Boss okay, I'll count off the tunes and I'll announce them, but we'll sort of not have a leader, I'll just count off tunes and announce. It won't be a big deal. Basie was never really an out-front man, he just played and he said a couple of things. We'll run it like that. Well the nostalgia of it kept for about six months and they could keep the gigs and maybe they'd cut off a little bit of the money from the price that they were getting, because Basie was booked for probably a year into his death. So they kept the same gigs. But then after six months the prices started going down, because the nostalgia, okay, he's passed on. The band's probably not any good. So the prices get lower, and there's no out front person, no person to say — because it's funny, I realized I don't mean to keep talking about business things — you know I even realized that like I was in the Basie band on and off for almost four years. And it's one humbling thing as a musician to go somewhere and I'd been playing with them for four years, I went to New York and I'd visit New York and people would say, "What you doing?" I'd say, "I'm playing with the Basie band, you don't know that?" And they're like, "No, are they still going?" And you're like wait a minute, I just got a standing ovation in Iowa last night. So you have to have really a lot of strength as an artist. Look I played at Hamilton College last night, and hopefully people enjoyed it, but nobody else knows about that then these people at Hamilton. So you have to have a lot of strength, because you think your name is getting out there in the people. It's a long process. That's what was happening to the Basie band. They needed some national press, and they didn't have one person to center in on, a star person. So they found out they had

prices went up and the band was able to survive. Because see they didn't cut anybody's salary, they just kept it, so you've got to keep a consistent thing coming in, and Thad did very well for the band. And for me it was like I was in heaven. Thad Jones, I'll just talk about him quickly, was like a father to me. I've followed him around like a little puppy. Because there are certain people I think that are born leaders. It's like they're put here, okay, you're going to be a leader. And he was one of those people. A natural born leader. And I sort of just followed him around. And everything he did he could inspire people on the bandstand. It's really, when I learn that, whatever band or organization there is, it takes upon the tone of the person that stands in front of it. In other words, Thad could be standing in front of the band and it would sound one way. He could leave and Woody Herman would walk in front of the band and it would sound different. The band takes upon — or the orchestra — Seiji Ozawa, he's going to sound different than if Eugene Ormandy, Eugene, just his presence is going to give — the people know they have to play differently for each person. So what Thad does is he was a natural born leader but he also could push people. And I know with me and I've spoken to many lead trumpet players about this, he could just look at you and go Rhhh, like that, and he would pull something out of you. He was a great conductor that way. And he also could make you do more than you thought you could do, which is what leaders are very good at. I remember he would write out these sets and I'd say, "Thad, you're going play 'Three Thirty' and then you're going to play another tune that's called 'Basie' it's Ernie Wilkins' chart, and 'Shiny Stockings' then you're going to play this new tune you wrote and then you're going to play 'Whirley-Bird?" Those are all chop busters. He goes, "That's right up your alley." And he'd smile. And I'm a young guy, very impressionable, I'm going geez you know he believes I can do this, maybe I can. And when I'd start to get tired he'd just look at me and go Rhhhh! And I'd get this burst of energy. It was like he was throwing electricity at me or something. So I'd go yeah, yeah I could do it. So that's the kind of magic that a person like that has, in addition to all the musicianship that he had. And the first night that he came on the band he had no reason to be studying old Sammy Nestico charts that we were playing a lot of. He conducted all of them. He didn't know those charts. He could conduct stuff he'd never even heard before.

MR: And his writing, did he have any conflict with the management as far as trying to put his own —

BS: Absolutely, yeah. They didn't want to play his charts. He wasn't happy there. This is the first time on tape folks, maybe I'll get assassinated for this. The guys in the band didn't want him there. Look, you know we just talked about change a minute ago. Change is a very difficult thing. I'm dealing with it constantly in my life. We're all dealing with it.

provided a boost for the band. They didn't want to play his music, they claimed that Basie never liked his music anyway, that's the reason he left, and he did leave because he wrote "Backbone," and "Big Dipper" for them and it didn't go over well. And he left and started his own band, which is fine. They said Basie didn't like him because his stuff was getting too modern, that he shouldn't be here now. The reality was people needed to have a name in front of the band. He made us rehearse. That band didn't like to rehearse. Look when you're on the road every day of the year, you just want to play your gig and go. Thad says, "No, we've got to rehearse, we need some freshness in this band." And we started rehearsing. And the band sounded better. And he made the band sound better. That's my opinion on that. Then he got cancer, Thad did a great tour with Caterina Valente, a singer from Germany, he wrote a whole album for her which if you ever come to my house I'll play the album, it's absolutely incredible, he wrote all the music, we recorded in Miami, went to Germany after the record came out, did a three week tour, and it was one of those tours where you get on the bus, the music is so incredible you can't wait to get to the gig that night, you're fidgeting as you're on the bus, because you can't wait to get off the bus to play, because you're playing this incredible music. That was what that tour was for me. Thad had cancer at that time and didn't tell anybody, but we knew, we knew he'd lost a ton of weight and he could hardly walk on stage, but once he got on stage he'd start dancing, conducting the music, he'd written a bunch of new charts, he wrote the best Stevie Wonder medley that I'd ever heard in my life, doing all this stuff. He'd walk off stage and it was like he was getting ready to die that minute, because he was so tired. But again that's what music can do to you. It can bring you to your feet and give you that energy.

MR: I like your impressions of him conducting. He had a certain, I mean, nobody conducted like him.

BS: Well when you talk to some other people about that, ask them how his conducting inspired them, I think you'll get the same response, really a way of giving you some energy and that kind of thing. So then he went back to Europe. I remember talking to him a couple of times on the phone. And then I'll never forget I went to the Village Vanguard one Monday night and I walked in and they have a picture of him on the thing conducting. And I paid my admission and I looked at that picture and I said that's my man, Thad. And I walked over and I think I saw somebody from the band and I said, "Did you know that Thad passed away today?" He says, "You're kidding." And I remember for me that was my first experience with somebody I loved dying. That was the first time I cried you know. Because I was very confused. You know you don't know when you first experience death, and we all experience it more as we get older, but this is

talk to him about music and what I should practice and he would help me when I was improvising, and things like that, and supported me in my life, and I just developed a love for him. And then all of a sudden somebody said well he's dead. So that was my first one with that, and I was just trying to deal with, well how do you deal with when somebody dies? But then you have to look back and say God I'm so thankful that I was able to sit by this guy who I love and was such a great inspiration, and it's a great memory for me.

MR: Really and the Vanguard orchestra, I mean it was an inspiration to so many players coming up and writers. That was great stuff.

BS: Sure, absolutely. Well then Frank came on after Thad. Frank Foster. And had a whole different approach to his way of running the band but it was still a great approach. And he was one of the first people who I saw who had so much music coming out of him. He and Thad, you know we always worry as musicians and artists, like is this just a fluke? Am I going to run out of ideas pretty soon? If you can be around some people like that, I mean Frank would sit on the bus with a pen, P-E-N, and write chart after — it was like he wrote too many charts almost. I'd say, "Frank, we haven't learned this other one yet." It's like he had all this, and it just had to come out. And so you learn by watching people like that, that each of us has this stuff in us. Now if we could just find where it is and what it is. It's there, you know, and don't be afraid, like don't stop it up, and get the cholesterol out and let it just come out. Because we all become so paralyzed with fear. So it's great to be around people who are, I call them like free spirits. It's just don't give a damn, just let it come out. Let your creativity come out, don't be afraid to be who you are. And it's like still I'm trying to learn how to do that. I'm trying to learn how to not be me, or try to learn how to not be afraid to be me. It's like what Tony Bennett once said, if you want to be something really different just try being yourself. It's that great, just trying to not be afraid of that. And so it's great to be around creative people like that, to check them out.

MR: Do you regret not finishing college at all?

BS: Well at this point I don't see what the specific degree I would have gotten, a bachelor's in performance, I mean I don't know what that would do for me in my life right now. My mother died of cancer about two and a half years ago and on her death bed she still was ranting and raving about wanting me to get a degree. But I hope that she understands and I think, Mom I'm not starving, I'm fine. And I still see what taking the time out to do that, what I've done and what — school was such an incredible experience for me, Eastman, an absolutely incredible experience. To play one day in a brass quintet, to play the next day in a symphony, to play the next day a recital with somebody. I was working outside of school in Latin bands to help me pay for my lunch and my laundry and all of that. Club dates, I was playing a lot of club dates. The guy was a gambler actually who

because I was big, I don't know. And then jingles I was already starting to do while I was in college. So I was starting to work already in college, constantly practicing. I was the first person in practice in the morning, the last one to leave. The guard was like okay there's Byron, I've got to kick Byron out of the practice room, it's eleven o'clock, he knows it closes at eleven, I've got to kick him out again. You know I was the first and last always. So the experience of being in school was an incredible experience, and I thanked my parents daily for giving me that and supporting me and helping me financially through that period. I mean they really sacrificed. And the one great thing I hope that I can do is give that to my own kids, that same kind of educational experience in college. So the time was not wasted but I just didn't get a degree from college. But from that my first gig out of college, well I left after my sophomore year to go tour with Clark Terry in Europe and that was like a six week tour in Europe and then a six week tour in the States. And then I didn't think I was going to go back. First of all my parents told me no when I asked them could I do it. And actually they put it like this they said, "What would we say if we said no that you can't do this?" I said, "I'd go anyway." And they went, "That's what we thought." So go ahead and do it, and just promise us that you'll go out and come back to school and take a leave of absence. So I came back.

MR: Well it's another kind of education for sure, to go on the road with Clark Terry.

BS: Absolutely. And to hear him play every night, a great experience. And then after that I came back to school and had more learning experiences, and getting ready to graduate I called up Clark and said, "Man, it's like my last semester of school and I have no idea what I'm going to do." And that's then another reason I made this vow to myself is if I can help some kids not freak out, some young college students not freak out when it becomes their senior year, if I — and what I think all universities should do — can start people when they're freshmen thinking about, you know you've got four years, but start thinking about what you might want to do as you leave this place, and what things you need to prepare to make sure you have the skills, etcetera etcetera. And so I had the skills playing the trumpet but I didn't know where I was going to go with it. So I called up Clark, "What am I going to do?" He says, "Don't worry about a thing, you'll get a call in a couple of days from somebody." I was like, "Okay, thanks Clark." He's always so good about that. And I thank him for always helping me and so many others out. A couple of days later Lionel Hampton called me up and said, "Hey Gates, he-he-he look here, Clark Terry told me you can play higher than Cat Anderson." I said, "Okay." He said, "Lookit I want you to come up to Albany, New York and play a gig with my band." I said, "Okay." He said "my manager'll be calling you." I said, "Well how much will the gig pay?" "I don't want to talk about no money, bbbbbut he'll tell you about it." So I went and did this

thinking about hiring me for this tour he has in Europe, but he said you told him I can play higher than Cat Anderson." He said, "Man, I tried to get the cat to hire you, now when you go and take a solo, just play some high notes and he'll like it." So I said okay. So here I am this Eastman student, first of all you know when you're in college there's a lot of music you play in college that you never play anywhere else, because they don't have the time to rehearse it, do you know what I'm saying? I don't know if you understand.

MR: Say that again.

BS: There's a lot of music in college that you won't play anywhere else, because the music just takes so long to prepare. In other words, not to get on another tangent, it's about time when you get in a professional arena, if you go to the Chicago Symphony, well let me give a better example. When you go play a show somewhere, they're going to try and make the music not so difficult because they might have an hour, two hours at the most, to rehearse it. They can't give you a bunch of incredibly hard stuff, they're going to give you something that is pretty readable. So I'd been playing this music that was impossible, all these time changes and really counting and doing all this stuff, and also very jazz but stiff. But my reading was — because at Eastman you read every day and it's tough stuff too. So I go to this thing and I'm reading my ass off because I'm used to reading this hard stuff. And the only thing I'm lacking is a good feel, I'm playing a little stiff, but the guys are looking at me like, "Wow, this cat really reads well." It comes time for my first solo, I said I've got to get this gig, and this man wants to hear some high notes, so I'm like blaaahh — and the cats are looking at me like what's this cat playing all these high notes, that's not too tasty. But I'm trying to get the gig. So he liked it and so then I left school even before I took my finals, and I told my parents I said oh I can make them up and I'll take them later, and I never did. But I got to go on a six week tour of Europe with Lionel Hampton's band, a guy named Frankie Dunlop was the drummer, formerly with Thelonious Monk, an incredible drummer. It was the first time I realized that a drum could be a melodic instrument. He'd play solos every night and I'd end up singing them when I got off stage. He'd play like [scats] It's like stuff like that. He was playing bebop on the drums. And I'd never heard — you know whenever I knew drummers solo, other than when I listened to like Max Roach with Clifford, it was like yeah I can sing that. But to be on stage with a guy that was playing bebop on the drums, it was like he would play songs [scats]. You know that song "Red Cross?" [scats] He'd be playing that, and he'd play bebop on the drums. And I was like wow! Because before when I'd hear kids play drum solos or in school and stuff it was like somebody was throwing some pots and pans down the stairs you know. And here was like this guy was playing music on the drums.

watching how he integrated entertainment into the whole thing was interesting. And then Lionel was the first guy, we're running a little short here, but Lionel was the first guy that he heard me playing and he said, "Yeah sometimes you sound like Louis Armstrong." And I had had a little, I always loved Louis, but he wasn't like my main thing, my man was Kenny Dorham and Lee Morgan. But I always loved Louis Armstrong. He said, "You know I recorded with Louis Armstrong." I said, "Of course, I know." He said, "Let's play, you and me, 'When You're Smiling.'" Because when Louis would play that it would seem like when he got to that last note it was the highest note in the world. So he says, "When you play it I want you to do that." So I started playing "When You're Smiling" with Lionel, we would just do it once a night. And his whole thing is, "I'm gonna' make you a star." He used to tell everybody that. Make you a star. Or he would say, "Stick with me, Gates, I'm gonna make some money, you dig?" So he would really say that I swear. So we started playing "When You're Smiling" and it started me listening to Louis again. I always had heard stuff — and really going back and focusing on him. Plus that feeling of Louis was in Lionel's playing, that happiness, that was in Lionel's playing too. So that's when I started getting a little bit into enjoying the music of Louis a little bit more.

MR: I had heard it in your playing last night every once in a while.

BS: Yeah.

MR: But can I ask you, what the gig ended up paying, with Hampton, at that point? Because he didn't have a reputation for —

BS: Well see time has gone by so I'll publicly tell the whole thing to you. But I'll try to leave as many names out as possible. I was told by someone that Europe was another story. The payment in Europe was good so I'll leave that alone. Very fair, very good. So by summer when we get back to the States, you will make $75 a night when we work. I said yeah it sounds great. I mean look when you're in college, and somebody says you're going to make $50 you scream and hollar. So I said great, beautiful. So we got to the States and I wanted a single room, because you want to practice and do my stuff. Most of the guys were doubles, I said I'm going to get a single room. Well my room was $60 for the night. Okay. I got my first paycheck and it was based upon $60 a night. So I told this person I said, "Excuse me, when we discussed this, it was $75." "What are you trying to rip me off? I said $60." So I learned the flip flop that people do. It was my first business lesson, right out of college, how people — maybe try to get things in writing. And you know my father always said always read what you sign, and always try to get what — And to this day, one thing I notice these days, this has nothing to do with music. I went to rent a car the other day and they wanted to have me sign something. People get nervous if you read

told me to sign. Well it just says that you're going to rent the car and if you do any damage — Well let me read that then! And then I said, "Well this here says that you're going to charge my card, that this document charges my card if it gets damaged, but there's no damages yet. I can sign this after. They say, "No, no, we just do that —" I say, "No that's not what this says. It says I agree to pay for the damages on the car. There's no damages on the car so you can't charge my credit card. I said you could just mark this sheet and say that there are damages if I sign it at the bottom. Well uh, so then I don't sign it see? So people, they even get — so that was my first business lesson was with Lionel Hampton, to try to see if you can get things in writing. Some people are reluctant too and sometimes there are certain people you do have to trust. There's a lot of guys to this day, a lot of the older jazz musicians, they don't do contracts, they don't — but they are people of their word. I know guys say they know promoters in Europe — I just don't want to name any names, but — but they have great relationships with them, word of mouth. And that's very important too, your bond and your word. Look, they have a friend in Europe who says, "Look, I'll book a tour for you, it'll be three weeks, pay you this much, I'll send you a ticket in a couple of weeks." They both agree to it and that's it, and everything's straight. And I have those agreements myself with people in Europe and all, nothing written down. And then I have people that especially have to have things written down. So my first good business lesson was with Lionel.

MR: Well you've done an awful lot in your career so far. Has there been a time — sometimes these are hard questions — has there been a ridiculous moment with jingles or something along the way that you can recall, stepping into a studio to have to do a really outlandish session?

BS: Well the most outlandish thing, especially in the thing for commercial music, is to be asked to improvise. You go why? Improvising is fun to do. Because the people don't know what they want so if you just are creative, they don't want that. They want a specific thing. Better to take the heat off yourself, have the writer write it, then you're in the clear. You just play what's on there. I hate improvising on jingles. When people start suggesting that, I don't say anything. Because you get things like this, "Hey" — you get it on the talk back mic, because it's so funny to be in the studio by yourself. It's going to happen to me Monday, it always happens, you're there by yourself, they've got the tape, they're in the booth, you're isolated from them and you can't hear what they're saying and they hear everything you do, say or breathe or play. And so you play and then you get this silence. And you're looking, trying to guess what they're saying. He sucks. He's terrible. He's out of tune — you know you're guessing. And then they come on, whether it's good or bad they go, "Sounds good, Byron, uh, Marjorie, do you want to tell him

whatever. "Yeah, could you play with more colors? Like think of spring. That's what we're looking for." I'm serious. This is what you get. That's when you start to go look — you almost want to go — and it's much better to go, "Look, if the writer writes something the pressure's on him, because I don't care about colors, I don't care about spring, I don't care about fall, I want to just play and get out of here. But those moments are only like fifteen minute periods, maybe like when you're playing a club date. You know I worked with — see this is all going to be on tape now — I worked with Lester Lanin sometimes, it's a club date, big club office, and it seems like you get on stage and you're watch stops. Four hours seems so long. What's that great thing that Einstein said, he said, "Time is so relative, it's like you can be with a beautiful girl and the time, one hour seems like a minute; where if you sit on a hot stove for a minute —" So it's really a relative thing there.

MR: Just to wrap up here, what's your impression of the work that goes on at Lincoln Center Jazz and the Smithsonian, well not the Smithsonian, the Carnegie Hall?

BS: Well I think that my one concern for young musicians is that they have a place to play, and hopefully I'll put myself in there, I'm a young musician. And I'm glad that those organizations give young musicians an opportunity to play. And I just want, I hope that jazz will go forward. We have to really be careful that — and I'll be honest with you, if I want to hear Count Basie's version of "One O'Clock Jump" from 19 thirty something, I'd rather hear the record.

MR: Then a group of people playing.

BS: Yeah, a group playing together. I mean I think they can play the song but I don't want to hear but Lester play on the solo, I don't want to hear his solo recreated. But that's my personal opinion. I think it's good for people to practice that stuff, and I practiced Louis Armstrong solos, I practiced Roy Eldridge solos, Kenny Dorham. I've got 25 I've transcribed and I try to play through almost like etudes. I work on all that stuff, but I don't really want to record it because that's what they did. And the difficult thing is to try to find your own identity as a jazz musician. And that's what I'm trying to work on now. It's the most humbling thing that can happen for you is to try to find your own voice in this music. And I just don't want, and I hope, I really enjoy the way I play in the Carnegie Hall Jazz Band. I like the way that we do it. We'll play like standards and stuff but do new arrangements of them, and that's really nice. You don't have to recreate anybody's solo or anything like that. But you know it's funny you've got to realize when the bands came up, when Thad started his band, it was like not let's recreate something, it was just like okay let's get some guys together and let's make some great music. It's hard with things, because then we are going the way of like the orchestras and that kind of stuff,

hope that some other bands come along, you know Maria Schneider has a great band, and that's the kind, that's a great example. And Carnegie Hall and Lincoln Center do too. There's something to be said for that struggle you have to go through as an artist. You know I've been with guys in Europe and terrible players sometimes and they'll go, "Well you know the government pays me, I got a grant to do a tour with my jazz band" and this and that, "and they gave me $100,000 for the year." And I'm just like man but you suck. I think there might be something to, you know when a guy goes to New York and there's not much stuff in the — what do you call it — there's no gigs for him, and he's just sitting in that greasy apartment. He says "man, I've got to be the best, because there ain't no work out here. I've got to get my stuff together." And that's what New York and places like that do for you. You've got to learn how to play then.

MR: Forced inspiration.

BS: That's right. It forces you to just be — there's something to that. You know we have a lot of media creations these days. It's fun just to see those groups and bands that really have just come out of nothing, it's fun.

MR: Well I have a feeling we're going to have to do Part Two down the road, because we didn't get to a lot of stuff I wanted to talk to you about but I know you're on your way. It's been a pleasure to have you here at the college, and I hope we can do it again. So thanks for your time.

BS: Thanks.